



THE MORNING KICKOFF

🏆 FIFA World Cup 26 — United States · Canada · Mexico · Quarter-finals — France–Spain semi-final is set

🏆 Semi-final 1 is set: France–Spain, Tuesday in Dallas

★ Crystal Ball called Spain 2–1 — the exact scoreline

📍 Tonight: Haaland (7) against Kane (5) in Miami

⚡ SUPER SUB, SEQUEL

THE WALL CRACKED. SPAIN DIDN'T.

Belgium did what nobody had managed in six games — they scored past Spain. It bought them 47 minutes of hope. Then Mikel Merino came off the bench and, for the second time in six days, won a World Cup knockout tie — 117 seconds after stepping on the pitch. France–Spain, the final everyone wanted, arrives a round early on Tuesday.

ALSO THIS MORNING

- ★ Crystal Ball, day four: Spain 2–1 was the call, Spain 2–1 the result — our first exact scoreline. Four winners from six.
- 📌 Belgium's brutal night: captain Tielemans injured in the warm-up, Courtois forced off mid-game.
- ⚡ Tonight England are without the suspended Quansah — a hole in the defence exactly where Haaland lives.

INSIDE TODAY'S EDITION

- P.2 Spain 2–1 Belgium — the night the record fell and Merino did it again
- P.3 Tonight: Norway–England in Miami — the best No. 9 against the deepest squad
- P.4 The Crystal Ball: our call on Haaland v Kane, with \$2.4m of live money
- P.5 Golden Boot: Messi and Mbappé on 8 — Haaland's turn to answer tonight
- P.6 The bracket: France–Spain locked in, one semi-final place left after tonight



Mikel Merino — two match-winners in six days, both from the bench

TONIGHT (CENTRAL EUROPE)



Norway – England



23:00

FULL PREVIEWS PAGE 3 →

⚡ THRILLER

📍 SoFi Stadium, Los Angeles



Spain

2 – 1

FULL TIME

Belgium



- ⊗ **Fabián Ruiz** 30' · rebound
- ⊗ **Merino** 88' · off the bench

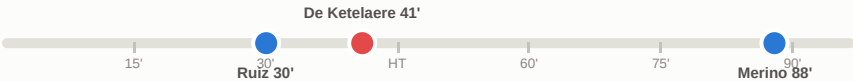
- ⊗ **De Ketelaere** 41'

The night began badly for Belgium before it began at all: captain Youri Tielemans pulled up injured in the warm-up. Yet they matched Spain punch for punch — Fabián Ruiz hammered in a 30th-minute rebound after Courtois spilled Olmo's shot, and four minutes before the break Charles De Ketelaere did what nobody in six games had done: he beat Unai Simón, ending Spain's perfect defensive record.

With Courtois himself forced off injured, the tie hung level until the 88th minute — when the script repeated itself. Substitute Mikel Merino, on for less than two minutes, turned home the rebound after backup keeper Lammens spilled Cubarsí's shot. Two knockout winners in six days, both from the bench. Spain march on to a Tuesday semi-final against France that feels like a final arriving early.

MATCH TIMELINE

● Belgium above · ● Spain below



★ STAR OF THE MATCH — AGAIN

Mikel Merino

The 91st minute against Portugal, the 88th against Belgium, 117 seconds after coming on. Whatever Spain pay their bench, it isn't enough.



Charles De Ketelaere

The man who finally scored past Spain — the only one in six games. A piece of history as consolation for a heartbreaking exit.

- ⚡ De Ketelaere's equaliser was the first goal Spain conceded in the entire tournament — Unai Simón's record run ended at last

- ⚡ Merino scored 117 seconds after coming on — his second knockout winner from the bench in six days

- 🚩 Belgium lost captain Tielemans in the warm-up and Courtois to injury during the game

➔ **WHAT IT MEANS** France–Spain in Tuesday's Dallas semi-final: the two form sides of the tournament, one step from MetLife. Belgium exit with heads high and a hospital ward of bad luck.

QF3 · THE BEST NO. 9 v THE DEEPEST SQUAD

Norway

England

23:00

00:00 +1

02:30 +1

17:00

15:00

Kick-off 5:00 PM ET at the stadium
📍 Hard Rock Stadium, Miami

Norway's first quarter-final in history against an England side that survived the Azteca with ten men. Haaland — born in Leeds while his father played there — has 7 goals and buried Brazil almost single-handed; England counter with Bellingham's form, Kane's ice and genuine depth. One complication: Quansah's suspension carves a hole in England's back line precisely where Haaland does his work.

- 👁️ Haaland can join Messi and Mbappé on 8 — or pass them
- 👁️ Bellingham against the tournament's biggest stage, again
- 👁️ The winner faces Argentina or Switzerland in Wednesday's Atlanta semi



KEY MAN · NORWAY

Erling Haaland

Seven goals, a nation's first quarter-final, and the country of his birth in the way. Norway don't need much possession — they need him twice.

TOMORROW NIGHT: QF4 — ARGENTINA-SWITZERLAND, KANSAS CITY

Argentina –

Switzerland

02:00

(+1)

Norway v England

★ OUR CALL: ENGLAND 2-1

RESULT AFTER 90 MINUTES



TO REACH THE SEMI-FINAL



LIVE MARKET · KALSHI PREDICTION MARKET · REGULATION-TIME WINNER · \$2.4M TRADED

Norway 24%

Tie 27%

England 52%

FORM

Norway have won the knockout ties that mattered, with Haaland scoring 7 of the team's goals. England survived a ten-man siege at the Azteca — battered, but battle-tested.

THE MATCH-UP

Haaland was born in Leeds while his father Alfie played in the Premier League. The striker England's football raised now stands between them and the semi-final.

FITNESS & FATIGUE

England are without Jarell Quansah, suspended since the Azteca red card — a gap at centre-back exactly where Haaland operates. Both squads have had a full week's rest.

WHERE THE MONEY IS

The biggest market of the tournament: \$2.4m traded on Kalshi, pricing England 52%, the draw 27%, Norway 24% in regulation. Respect for Haaland is baked into that 24.

THE VERDICT England have more ways to win, and the market agrees. But Norway only need the game to be close for Haaland to decide it, and the man marking him is a stand-in. England — with less confidence than the number suggests, and a real chance the family is watching extra time at 1 AM.

The Crystal Ball is for family bragging rights only. Probabilities blend live prediction-market prices with our own reading of form, fitness and history. Entertainment — not financial or betting advice. Record so far: 4 winners from 6, one exact scoreline.



Lionel Messi

Plays Switzerland in tomorrow night's Kansas City quarter-final

8



Kylian Mbappé

Rests until Tuesday's blockbuster semi-final against Spain

8



Erling Haaland

Tonight in Miami — a brace takes the outright lead

7



Tie-break: assists, then minutes played. A Haaland brace tonight would take him top outright.

⚡ NUMBERS OF THE DAY

117s

Merino's time on the pitch before scoring — his second bench winner in six days

41'

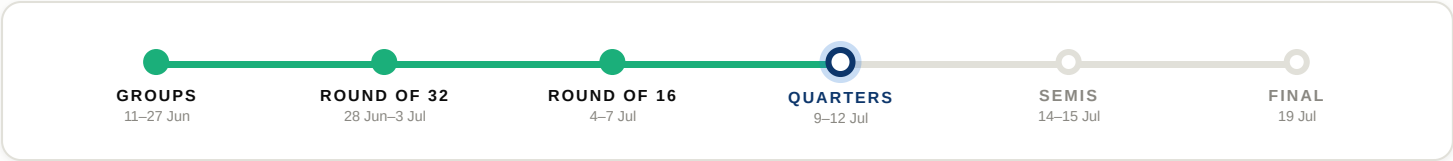
De Ketelaere's strike — the first goal Spain conceded in the whole tournament

\$2.4m

Already traded on tonight's Norway–England, the biggest market of the Cup

8–8–7

Messi, Mbappé, Haaland — and only Haaland plays tonight



KNOCKOUT BRACKET

Quarter-finals 9–12 July · Semi-finals 14–15 July

QUARTER-FINALS

QF1 · FT Thu · France won 2–0 · · Boston

France

Morocco

QF2 · FT Fri · Spain won 2–1 · · Los Angeles

Spain

Belgium

QF3 · Tonight · 23:00 · · Miami

Norway

England

QF4 · Sun · 02:00 (+1) · · Kansas City

Argentina

Switzerland

SEMI-FINALS

Tue 14 July · 21:00 · Dallas · Dallas

France vs Spain — SET

Wed 15 July · Atlanta · Atlanta

Tonight's winner vs Argentina/Switzerland

THE FINAL

Sunday 19 July

MetLife Stadium, New York / New Jersey

YOUR WEEK IN FOOTBALL

Monday 6 — Sunday 12 July

SAT
11 Jul

QF3 Norway–England · 23:00

SUN
12 Jul

QF4 Argentina–Switzerland · 02:00 (+1)

MON
13 Jul

Rest day

TUE
14 Jul

SF1 France–Spain · Dallas

WED
15 Jul

SF2 · Atlanta

THU
16 Jul

Rest days to the final

SUN
19 Jul

THE FINAL · MetLife



See you tomorrow morning.

Next edition: did Haaland answer? The Norway–England report, plus the Crystal Ball on Messi against the Swiss wall.